

Arthritis and Mental Health in the UK

Living with arthritis affects mental health too. UK guide to depression and anxiety with arthritis, NHS support options, and practical coping strategies.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-11 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis doesn't just affect your joints — it can have a profound impact on your mental health. Studies show that people with arthritis are **2-3 times more likely** to experience depression and anxiety compared to the general population.

The Connection Between Arthritis and Mental Health

- Chronic pain activates the same brain regions as emotional distress
 - Loss of independence — difficulty doing things you once managed easily
 - Social isolation — reduced mobility limits social activities
 - Fatigue — persistent tiredness drains motivation and mood
 - Unpredictability — not knowing when flares will strike causes anxiety
 - Identity changes — adjusting to life with a chronic condition
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Warning Signs to Watch For



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- Persistent low mood lasting more than 2 weeks
- Loss of interest in activities you previously enjoyed
- Withdrawing from friends and family
- Difficulty concentrating or making decisions
- Changes in appetite or sleep (beyond arthritis-related disruption)
- Feelings of hopelessness about the future

NHS Mental Health Support

If you're struggling with your mental health alongside arthritis, several NHS services can help:

- NHS Talking Therapies — self-refer for free CBT, counselling, and guided self-help at [nhs.uk](https://www.nhs.uk)
 - Your GP — can prescribe antidepressants that are safe alongside arthritis medications
 - Pain management programmes — NHS programmes that address the psychological aspects of chronic pain
 - Social prescribing — your GP can refer you to community activities, volunteer groups, and exercise programmes
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Self-Help Strategies



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- Stay connected — join an online or local arthritis support group

- Move regularly — exercise releases endorphins that improve mood
 - Practice mindfulness — the NHS recommends the Headspace or Calm apps
 - Set small, achievable goals — accomplishment builds confidence
 - Talk about it — sharing your feelings reduces their power
 - Keep a gratitude journal — noting positives shifts mental focus
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Urgent Help

If you're in crisis or having thoughts of self-harm:

- Samaritans — call 116 123 (free, 24/7)
- Crisis text line — text SHOUT to 85258
- NHS 111 — for urgent medical advice
- A&E; — if you're in immediate danger

Your mental health matters as much as your physical health. Don't hesitate to ask for help — these services exist for you.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and mental health in the uk?

Short answer: Arthritis can affect mental health, with people 2-3 times more likely to experience depression and anxiety. This link is due to factors like chronic pain, loss of independence, social isolation, and fatigue. Warning signs include persistent low mood or withdrawing from others. NHS resources such as Talking Therapies, GP support, and pain management programmes are available.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk